
Chapter 1 — Group 1

CODEPENDENCE & HONESTY

[Instructions: Read this chapter prior to coming to your first group. Answer the questions at the end of the chapter before coming to group. (Write them out in the spaces provided.) In group, you will simply share what your answers were and participate in a brief discussion held by the group facilitator. If both you and your partner are attending the same group, each of you should have your own workbook and separately answer the questions.

Relationships can be painful. Sometimes the people we love the most cause us the most pain. Many people seem to believe that they have no other choice, that they have to accept the hardships and problems that come in living with a “difficult” person. But it doesn’t have to be that way. Relationships *can* change.

Changing the relationships you are in requires an understanding of one very basic fact. You may not like this fact, but it’s still true. Here it is: **You can only change yourself. You cannot change the other person.** Let’s explain this a little bit.

Less than an hour before these words were written, the first author of this book received a phone call from a young woman. She had performed a search on the internet after her counselor suggested it to her and eventually came up with my number after finding some books that had been written about “her” problem. She called me out of desperation. She explained that the problem was her husband. He had just been diagnosed with a mental disorder. It “explained” his reasons for committing crime, physical/emotional abuse, chemical abuse, and emotional outbursts. “I was told by the counselor that he’s antisocial,” she said.

I asked her how long he’d had these problems?

“Ever since we met,” she explained. “But he’s gotten worse and worse. I just found out that he stole a check from my purse last week and wrote a bad check. And I know that he’s done this a lot of other times, too. He lies about it and he lies about everything else. He’s promised to change again and again, but he never does. He says he’s sick and wants help. He’s willing to do anything. He just needs a program that will really help him.”

I asked how old they were?

“I’m 42 and he’s 46,” she replied.

I asked what sort of counseling or help he had up to that point?

“He’s been to AA, in drug treatment, been to psychiatrists, had a counselor for years, and been in several other programs. He was in one program for 9 months. He says he wants help and that he’ll do anything. What can we do?”

“Have any of the programs he’s been in helped him?” I asked.

“Well, she said, “he seems a little better after he gets out, but soon he’s back to the way he was or even worse. I just don’t know what to do.”

I found out that she was a little afraid of her husband and that they had an 8 year-old daughter. He’d never really worked anywhere for any length of time and he stole, conned others, and spent all of their money on drugs. She said he’d never been violent with her, but he was becoming more and more aggressive and emotional. He “earned his living” basically as a thief and a con artist.

“I don’t know if there is anything *you* can do *for* him,” I said after a long pause. “It seems to me that you have to decide what *you* are going to do.”

“What does that mean?” she asked.

“It means that **the only thing you can control in this situation is you.**” I replied. “You have already said that everything that you have done to help him hasn’t worked and that you are afraid of him. He says that he loves you and the child, but what does his behavior say about it? You believe that he’s going to

eventually go to jail for stealing, drugs, or maybe worse things. And he's shown you time and again that *everything in your life is up to you*. Who pays the bills? — you do. Who takes care of your child? — you do. Who goes to work every day? — you do. Who seems to be taking responsibility for *his* problems? — you. Have you somehow been allowing him to be irresponsible?" I asked.

After pausing, she replied, "well, yes. I've tried to cover up for him and make excuses. I've gone to the people who he wrote the bad checks to and promised to take care of them. I know that he's used drugs in the house and he's come home lots of times stoned. I've threatened him about it, though. I've told him that if it doesn't stop it he'll have to get out of the house."

"And did he stop?" I asked, already knowing the answer.

"He did at first," she replied. "But he always starts up again."

"So you've made some empty threats about ending the relationship if he doesn't get clean and change?" I asked.

"Yeah, I've made a lot of threats. But he's a good father."

"What does he do with his family that shows you he's a good father?" I immediately asked.

"At least he doesn't abuse the child or beat me up," she quickly replied.

"It sounds like you've defended him with that statement before?"

"Yeah," she said with a sigh.

"So, he's a good father because he doesn't abuse his child or you? That's it? Does he do anything like a 'good father' might do? You know, things like working to provide for his family, being a stable and reliable source of support, keeping home life safe, making sure everyone's basic needs are met, and showing some real day-to-day care and concern?"

"Nope, it's just the opposite," she said. "All he does is cause us more problems."

"So now you have a clear picture," I replied. "Everything you've done to change him hasn't worked. You defending him doesn't change him, either. All it does is allow him to keep on doing the same things leaving you behind to clean up his mess. And it sounds like you've *settled* for a man who doesn't actually do anything positive for the family, he just doesn't beat you up. I don't know if this is all you want in a love relationship, but it sure looks like all you're getting. The only thing that you can control in this is you. You have to choose whether you want to remain with him under these circumstances. You have to set some limits and then stand by them. You have already chosen to remain in this situation for years — and now you have to choose again."

CODEPENDENCY

The situation above is real. Very real. Unfortunately, it is played out in the relationships of addicts, alcoholics, criminals, and other destructive people with their 'loved ones' day after day.

Some years ago, the term *codependency* was used to describe these situations. Codependency is a subject with lots of strong opinions and viewpoints. But the opinions don't really matter here. What really matters is dealing with family problems and having each person in a relationship become a happy, successful, and fulfilled person.

Codependency results from the *process* of relationships. One way to look at it is to think about your early family life. There were probably some topics your parents didn't want to discuss. Maybe you even noticed times when your parents became angry with each other and began arguing. They probably argued about the same things, again and again. That's the way codependency occurs. Sometimes, when people don't discuss and solve the real problems they have with each other, they develop resentments. These resentments can lead to many unhealthy behaviors. For example, people who resent each other often avoid contact with each other. They may also avoid responsibilities they have with the other person. They may also use their children against the other person. It is complicated and no one has ever perfectly defined codependency.

Perhaps the simplest and most accurate definition of codependency is this: **It is an unhealthy pattern of behaviors that develops because of a relationship.**

I. A Codependence Example — Questions

Here is a simple example of how codependence might begin: Let's say that a young woman meets a man that she is really attracted to. On their first date, the man pulls out a cigarette and starts smoking. He looks briefly at her and notices a different expression on her face. So he asks her, "Do you mind if I smoke?"

Let's also say that the woman really doesn't like cigarette smoke, but she really likes this guy. So she quickly replies, "Oh, no, it's okay, I don't mind."

1. **Why do you think she did this? Think about this for a moment and write your answers below.**

It might be uncomfortable sharing something that she didn't like something with a person she doesn't know well, but might worry that it could truncate the relationship. It could lead to him getting uncomfortable and maybe she wanted to keep him comfortable and take care of him first.

2. **Do you think that the young woman felt bad about herself?** I don't think that's a safe assumption, just that she was insecure.

3. **What do you think the man would have done if she had asked him not to smoke?** _____

Either he would have stopped smoking and talked about it, or she quickly would have found out it was in her best interest to find a new relationship.

4. **Do you believe that a man respects a women who immediately gives in to him?** _____

No one who doesn't show respect for themselves usually gets respected by the people around them.

5. **Did she "lie" to him? Yes, she was** dishonest about her feelings.

6. **What do you believe the guy would have thought if the woman said something like, "I'd prefer that you not smoke around me."** It's pretty common for that request and he might have been okay with it. If he wasn't, it's time to find someone who doesn't smoke.

7. **What would you have done in this situation?** _____

I would have shared that I am uncomfortable with or don't like that behavior and I don't want to be around it.

II. Taking Codependence Further — Questions

Many professionals believe that codependence is a type of "self-sacrifice" where one person gives in to the wishes of another. This could also mean that one person in a relationship changes his or her behavior to what the other person wants. Let's take our example and go a little further with it.

Let's say the young man and woman in the smoking situation described above start dating more and more. When they go out to eat, the man always asks for seating in a smoking area. Despite the fact that the woman hates cigarette smoke, she doesn't say anything. Weeks go by, they go out to eat 10 times or so (always sitting in the smoking section), and every time they are together the man smokes in the car. The woman really doesn't like the smoke, but she thinks to herself that she really likes the guy and doesn't want to risk losing him.

1. What do you think she should do now? She needs to share her feelings. And see a counselor
2. Why? She needs to not let herself be miserable to accomodate someone else.
3. Is the woman "self-sacrificing" anything? Yes, she is.
She is sacrificing her happiness thinking that being
4. What is she "giving up?" with someone is making her happy.
5. Do you think that she feels bad about this at all? From the text, it sounds like she's miserable with the smoking situation.
6. If they got married, do you think she would eventually ask him to quit smoking around her?
No, if they're together now, she knows him well enough to have asked him to stop.
7. What do you think the man might say when she asked him to refrain from smoking around her?
There's a good chance he will stop, but she should know if he respects her wishes or move on.

III. What Are You Sacrificing?

You are probably in this group because you either are — or are in a relationship with — a drug or alcohol abuser, an offender, someone on probation/parole, or at least have a family member that has some problems. Your relationship has probably caused you to change your behavior for that person. It has probably caused you to "self-sacrifice" or maybe do what seems to be the opposite — for some reason.

Some professionals call the persons deeply involved with addicts and criminals "*co-addicts*" or "*co-criminals*" because somehow the relationship allows the person to stay an addict or a criminal.

In this final section of Chapter 1, we want you to be **honest**. This is really important. We don't want to know anything here that can be held against you or your partner. We just want to give you a real opportunity to decide whether you want to make any changes in your life. But first, you have to become aware of what is going on in the relationship. Your awareness depends on you being honest.

1. List three to five (3-5) things (*your* wants, desires, needs, wishes, personal goals, activities) that you have been "giving up" (sacrificing) because of a relationship to an addict, criminal, alcoholic, or other important person in your life.

1. New clothes
2. Time to myself
3. Friends
4. Hobbies
5. Adventure

2. Look at the list you made above. For each of the things you wrote down there, write down how long ago you gave it up.

1. _____
2. I gave these up early in the relationship attempting to adapt to the
other person and what they wanted. There's no time I gave each
3. up, this was the whole relationship.
4. _____
5. _____

3. Now write your reason, as best as you can remember it, for giving up each thing.

1. _____
2. I was happy someone liked me enough to stay around me, so I
tried to keep that by maintaining what they wanted.
3. _____
4. _____
5. _____

4. Write down whether or not you would still like to do each of those things — a **yes** means you still want it, a **no** means you don't want it.

1. yes
2. yes
3. yes
4. yes
5. yes

5. Using *three words or less* for each of the things you have “given up” or sacrificed for the relationship, write how it has made you feel about yourself. (For example, you might write: “I feel weak”; “strong”; “depressed”; “like a martyr”; “rejected”; “angry”; “hurt”; “confused”.) Use any words that describe how each thing you have sacrificed makes you feel about yourself.

1. raggedy
2. stressed
3. lonely
4. depressed
5. hopeless

If you have filled out this chapter before group and shared your responses with the group, you will be asked to move on to the next chapter.